

PLAB PATHWAY

For International Medical Graduates

A step-by-step guide from medical school to UK medical registration

BEYOND MEDICAL SCHOOL

The PLAB Pathway in a Glance



1. Complete Medical School

- Obtain your Primary Medical Qualification (PMQ).
- You may be able to proceed after passing final examinations even if the formal certificate is not yet issued, subject to GMC requirements.
- Keep your medical school records and documentation accessible.

2. Check Your PMQ

- Confirm that your medical qualification is acceptable to the GMC.
- Check the GMC's current guidance on acceptable overseas qualifications.
- Being listed in the World Directory of Medical Schools (WDOMS) does not by itself guarantee GMC acceptance.

3. English Language Requirement

KEY POINT

Demonstrate the required knowledge of English.

•TESTS RECOMMENDED BY GMC

- OET Medicine: at least Grade B in each component.
- IELTS Academic: overall 7.5, with at least 7.0 in each component.

Validity of both tests is 2 years.

IMPORTANT

The GMC accepts other forms of evidence in specific circumstances—check current requirements.

4. Create a GMC Online Account

- Create your GMC Online account.
- Account creation itself is free. Payments are only made for registration of the licensing exams.
- Use the account to manage your PLAB application, bookings and registration.
- Setting up the account does not guarantee GMC registration; eligibility is separate.

5. Primary-Source Verification

KEY POINT

International medical graduates generally need their medical qualification verified.

ECFMG/Intealth supports the GMC verification process through EPIC (Electronic Portfolio of International Credentials).

IMPORTANT

- Set up a MyIntealth account and confirm identity (\$110*).
- Once you establish a MyIntealth account, you will be issued a MyIntealth ID
- Establish an EPIC Portfolio (\$35*), then upload the required qualification(\$35*)
 - Upload the required qualification(s) for verification.
 - The qualification is verified directly with the awarding medical school.
 - *Fees are subject to change.*
 - Note: Start early because verification may require action from your medical school.**

6. Register for PLAB 1

- Meet the GMC eligibility requirements.
- Book PLAB 1 through GMC Online.
- PLAB is one route to GMC registration for international medical graduates.

7. PLAB 1 — Written Exam

- 180 multiple-choice questions.
- Assesses the knowledge needed for safe medical practice in the UK.
- Pass mark is not a fixed number and is determined through the GMC's standard-setting process.
- Common preparation resource: Plabable.

Important Update for Ghanaian Candidates

PLAB 1 IN ACCRA

PLAB 1 will no longer be offered in Accra from February 2027.

WHAT THIS MEANS

Ghanaian candidates will need to select another available PLAB 1 location.

Examples include Nigeria, Kenya, South Africa and other listed locations—or travel to the UK.

BEFORE BOOKING

Always check GMC Online for current availability before booking.

8. PLAB 2 — Clinical Exam

KEY POINT

PLAB 2 can be booked after your PLAB 1 result has been issued.

IMPORTANT

You must pass PLAB 2 within two years of passing PLAB 1.

IMPORTANT

16 clinical scenarios; each station lasts 8 minutes.

IMPORTANT

Designed to reflect real-life clinical practice.

IMPORTANT

Currently held in Manchester, UK.

PLAB 2 preparation academies are optional and are not affiliated with or required by the GMC. They provide practical OSCE practice mock exams and clinical simulation. Candidates may choose an academy based on their individual learning needs and budget.

9. Apply for GMC Registration

- After passing PLAB 1 and PLAB 2, apply for GMC registration with a licence to practise.
- Completed internship/housemanship generally supports an application for full registration.
- Applicants without an internship may be eligible for provisional registration if they meet GMC requirements.
- Requirements may include: valid passport/identity documentation, PMQ, English-language evidence, Certificate of Good Standing, internship/housemanship details, and other evidence requested by the GMC.

GMC Registration

- Once approved, your name is added to the medical register.
- You receive a GMC reference number.
- You can practise medicine in the UK with the appropriate registration and licence to practise.

10. Apply for Jobs

- Set up profiles on NHS Jobs and relevant NHS Trust/Health Board career pages.
- Search for suitable medical posts.
- GMC registration does not automatically provide a job.
- Job opportunities vary by specialty, location and time.

PLAB Fees — Check Before Applying

PLAB 1

£283* — 2026 fee listed by GMC

PLAB 2

£1,036* — 2026 fee listed by GMC

OTHER COSTS

English test, EPIC verification, travel, accommodation and GMC registration may add to your total.

IMPORTANT

*Fees are subject to change. Always confirm current fees on official GMC/Intealth websites.

KEY NOTES

- PLAB is only the beginning. Passing the exams and obtaining GMC registration does not guarantee a UK medical job.
- Be prepared for a competitive job market. Employment has become more difficult for international medical graduates, particularly those seeking their first NHS position.
- Have a plan beyond PLAB. Start thinking early about your CV, portfolio, clinical experience, references and preferred specialty.
- Be flexible. Your first UK job may not be in your preferred specialty or location.
- Stay informed. UK recruitment policies and requirements can change, so regularly check official GMC and NHS sources.
- Plan your finances and timeline carefully. Consider examination fees, travel, GMC registration, visa costs and the possibility of spending time applying for jobs after registration.
- **Don't choose PLAB solely because it appears easier or cheaper than other international pathways. Consider whether the UK pathway fits your long-term career goals.**

BEYOND MEDICAL SCHOOL

Mentorship • Exposure • Opportunity

Helping medical students move from uncertainty to a clear, realistic career roadmap.

Explore pathways. Learn from professionals. Plan intentionally.

BMS • PLAB PATHWAY